

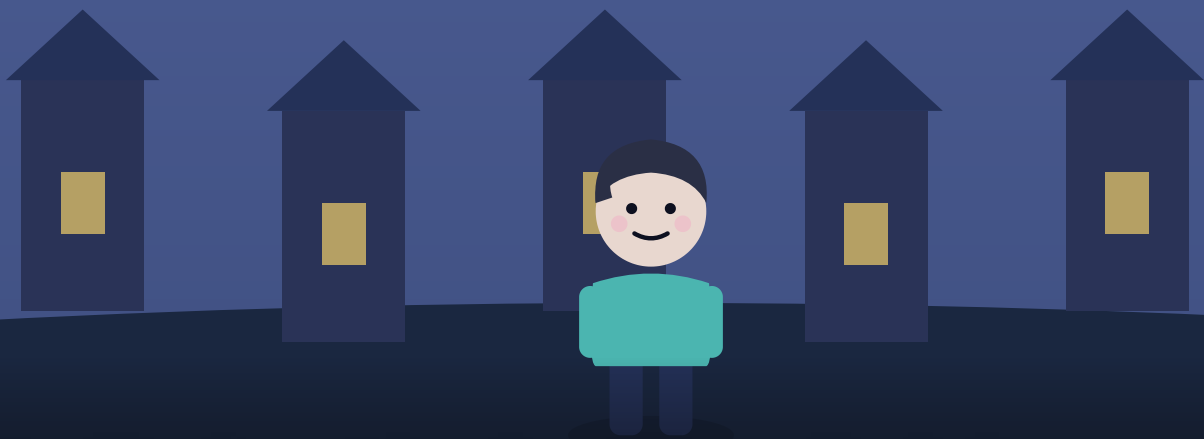


THE LITTLE REWRITES

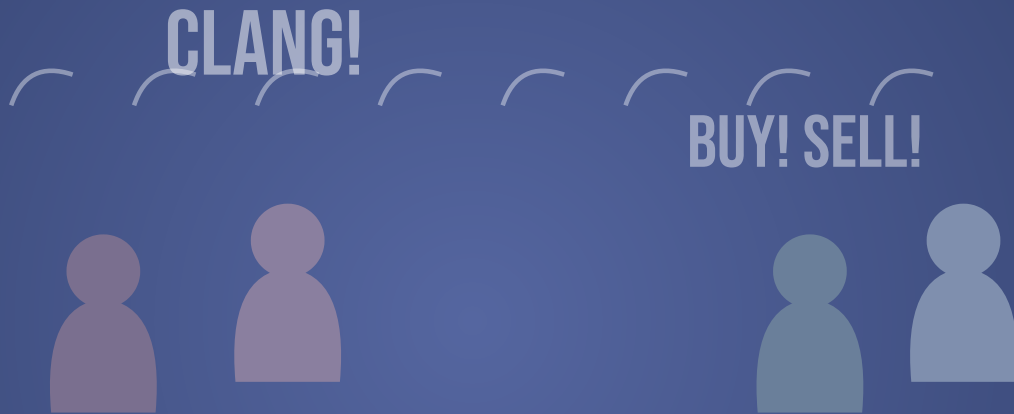
THE BOY WHO TALKED TO THE STARS

A story about a mind that works a little differently — and a world that needs it.

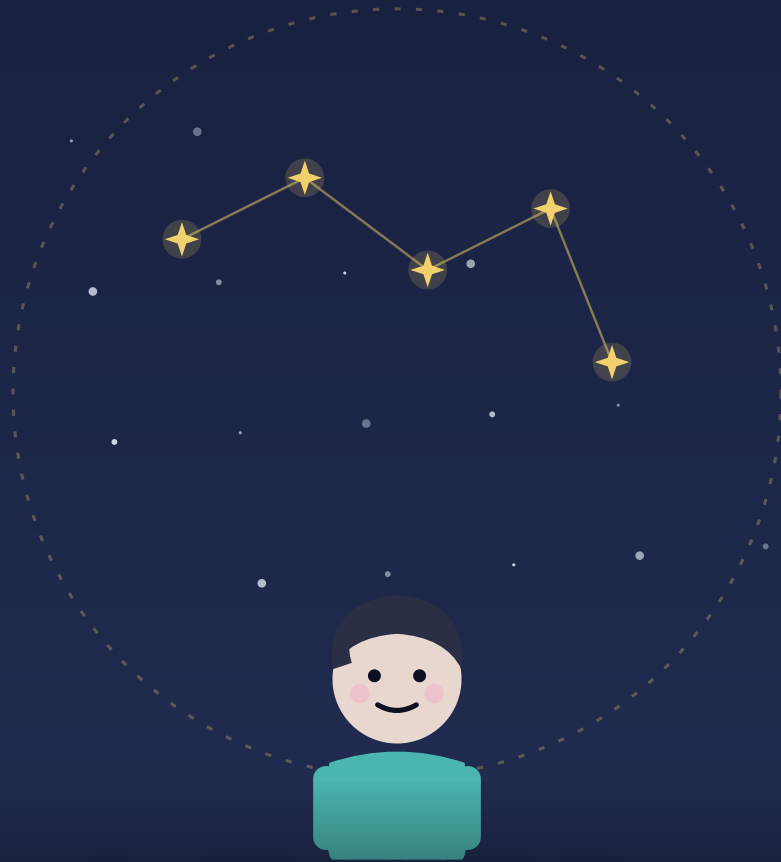
MK PARRISH



In a kingdom at the edge of the sea lived a boy
named Theo, who did not do things the way
the other children did.



When the square grew loud and clanging, Theo pressed his hands over his ears and squeezed his eyes shut until the noise stopped climbing up his skin. And at the edge of it all, he lined up his stones — smallest to largest, dark to light, in a row as straight as a ruler.

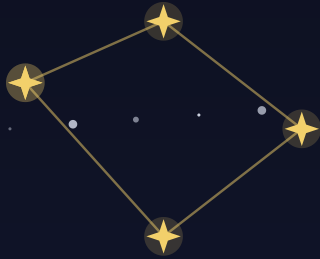


The townspeople said he was off in his own world. They were right about one thing. Theo *did* have a world. It was only that nobody had ever thought to ask him what was in it.

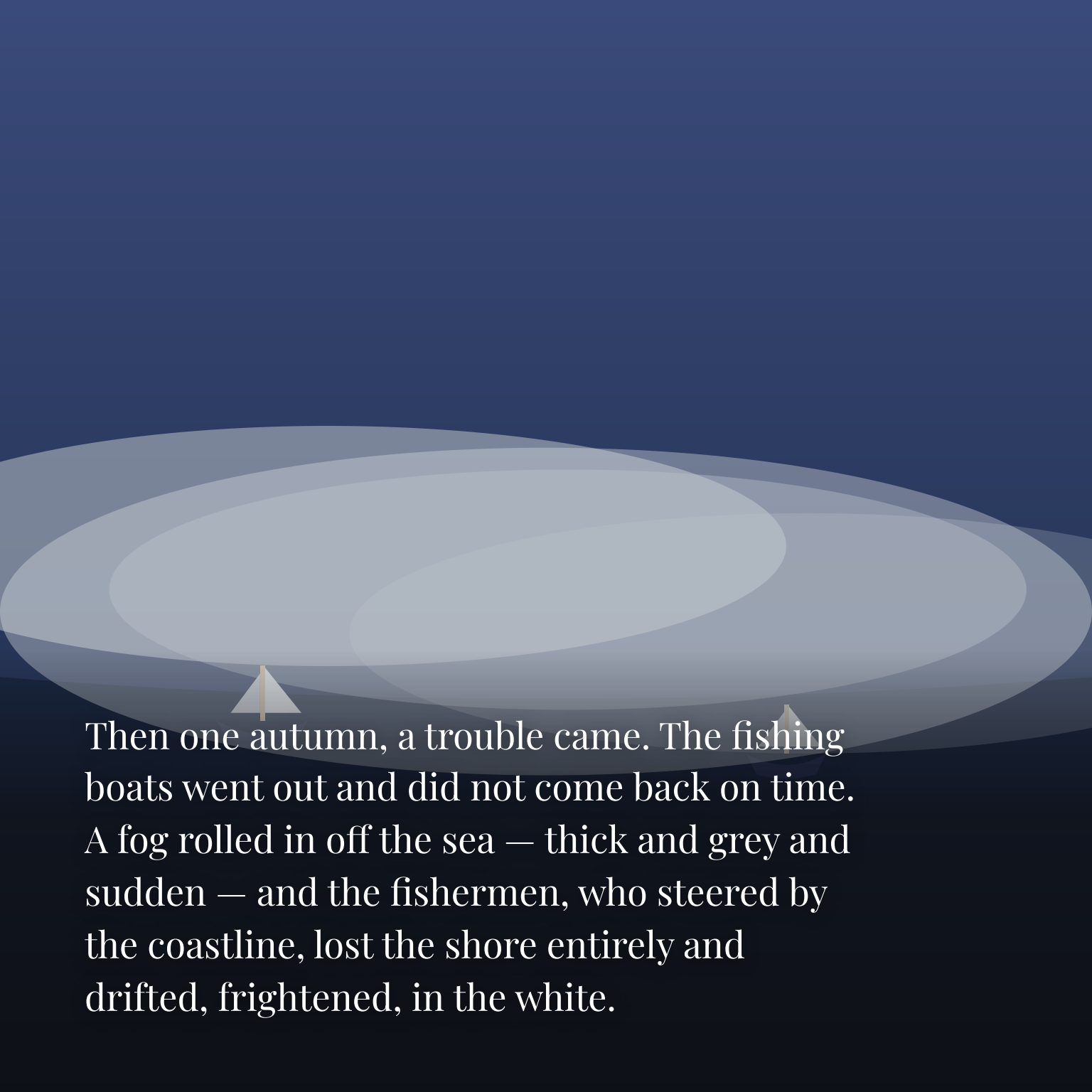


But every night, when the kingdom went dark and quiet and the terrible noise finally stopped, Theo climbed the hill behind his house and looked up. And the stars — the stars *talked* to him. Not in words. In patterns. In the slow, exact turning of the sky.





He knew them all — every point of light, where it rose, where it set, which ones traveled together and which stood alone. He knew the sky the way the other children knew each other's faces. It never got too loud. It never asked him to hurry. And there, Theo felt the thing he almost never felt in town: he felt like he *fit*.



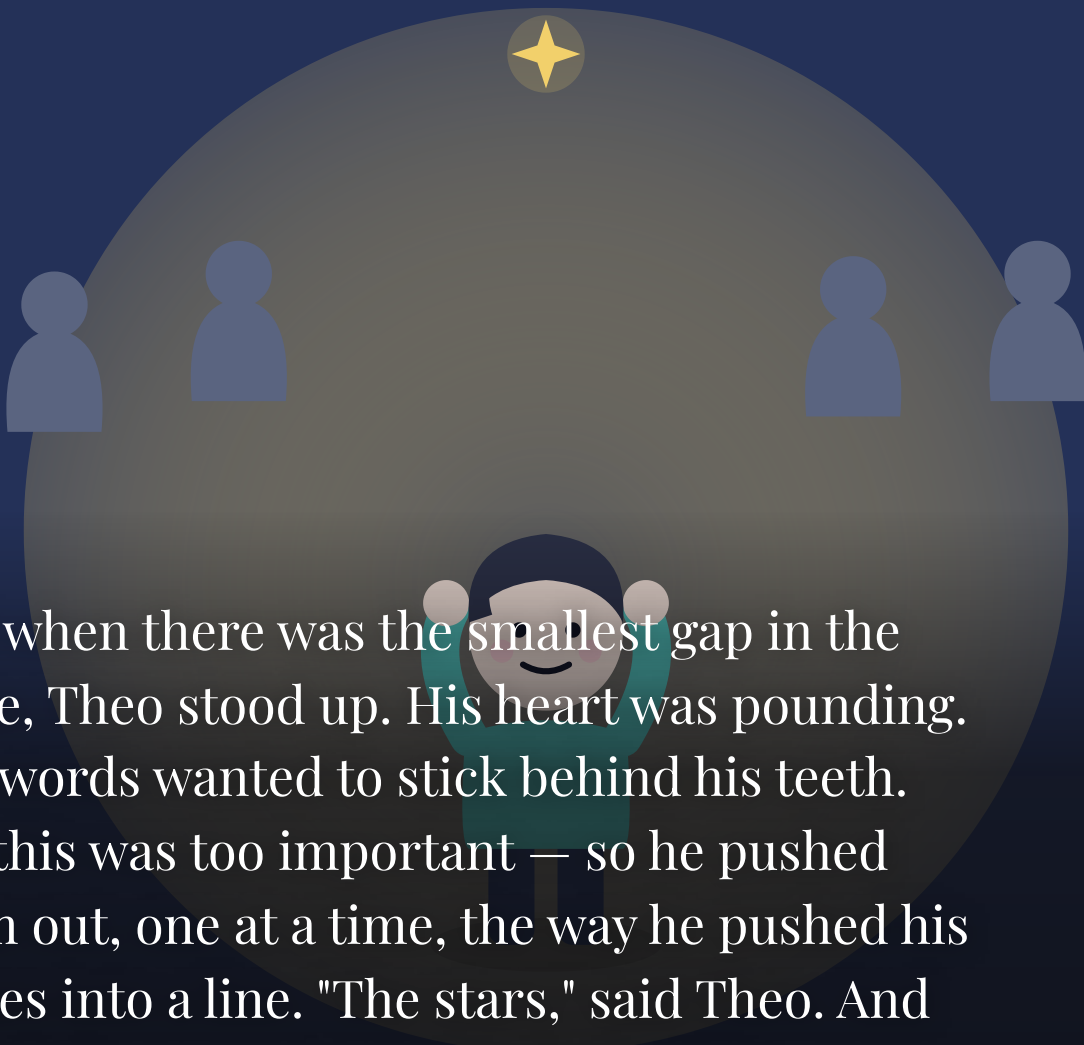
Then one autumn, a trouble came. The fishing boats went out and did not come back on time. A fog rolled in off the sea — thick and grey and sudden — and the fishermen, who steered by the coastline, lost the shore entirely and drifted, frightened, in the white.

BIGGER BELLS!

LOUDER!



The whole town gathered, and the clever grown-ups argued. Bigger lanterns! Louder bells! Longer ropes! None of it would work in a fog you could not see or hear through. The square got louder and louder — and at the edge, hands over his ears, Theo was listening. Theo was always listening, even when it looked like he was somewhere else.



And when there was the smallest gap in the noise, Theo stood up. His heart was pounding. The words wanted to stick behind his teeth. But this was too important — so he pushed them out, one at a time, the way he pushed his stones into a line. "The stars," said Theo. And the whole square turned to look at him.



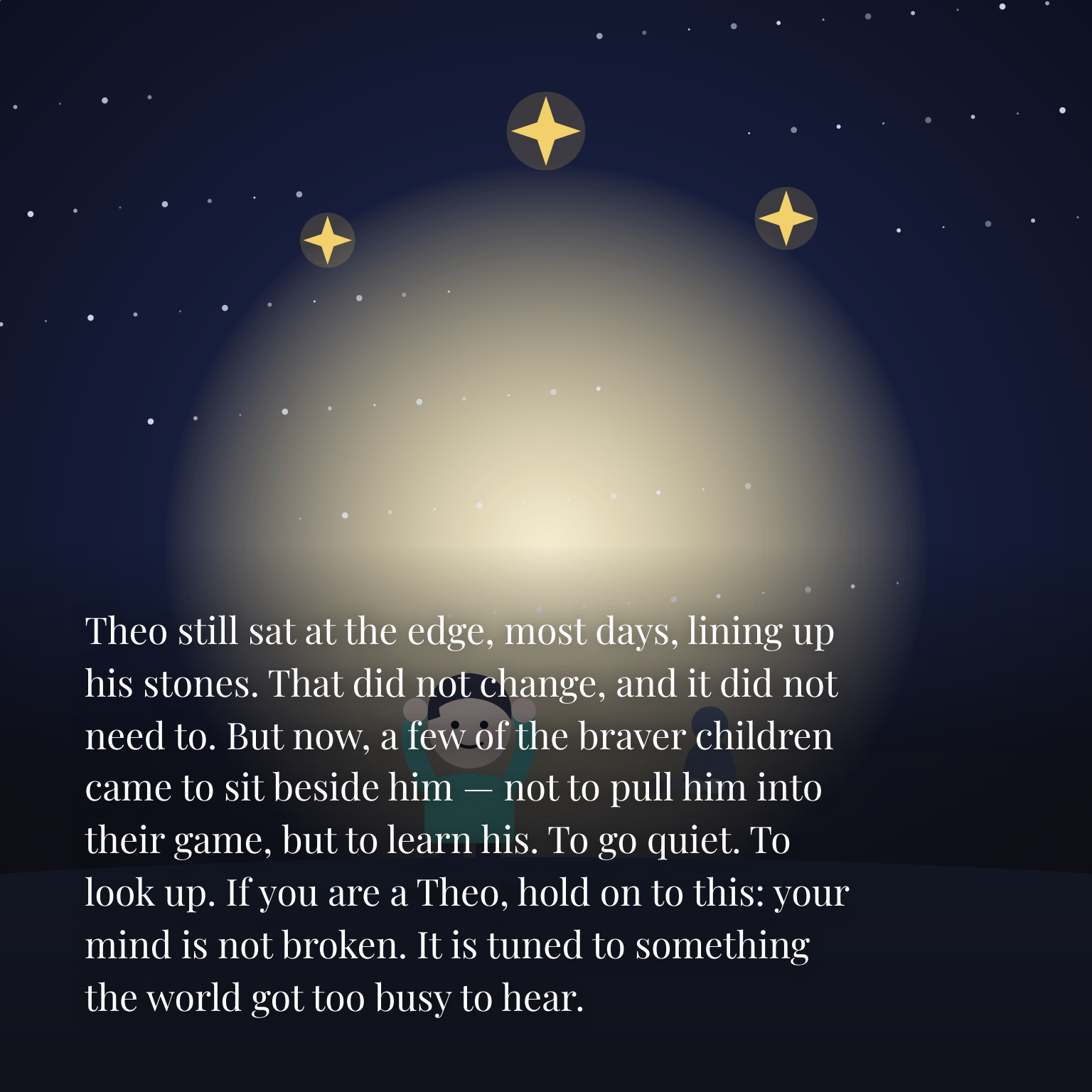
"The fog is low. It sits on the water. But it is thin at the top — if you look straight up, the stars come through. And the stars don't move like the land moves. They come back to the same place every night, exactly. When you can't see the shore," said Theo, "look up. The sky will bring you home."



All that winter, Theo stood on the hill with the fishermen gathered around him, and he taught them the sky. He was patient in a way none of them expected — because the sky had taught him patience first. He never got flustered. He never rushed. And for the first time, the whole town was grateful for exactly the way Theo's mind worked.



When the fog came now, the fishermen tipped their heads back and found Theo's stars — and the sky brought every last boat home.



Theo still sat at the edge, most days, lining up his stones. That did not change, and it did not need to. But now, a few of the braver children came to sit beside him — not to pull him into their game, but to learn his. To go quiet. To look up. If you are a Theo, hold on to this: your mind is not broken. It is tuned to something the world got too busy to hear.

FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

Some children experience the world turned up too loud — the lights, the noise, the rush of it climbing up their skin. They line things up. They know everything about one enormous thing. And they light up like a whole city when they find the one place, or person, that finally makes sense. This is a story for autistic and neurodivergent children, and for everyone who loves one. When you finish, don't ask your Theo to come down off the hill. Climb up. Ask them what the stars are saying. They have been waiting for someone to ask.